

The Bloody Cup Campaign

Piloting Menstrual Cup Adoption Across All Six Geopolitical Zones of Nigeria

Implemented by Girls for Development Goals Foundation (GDGF) in partnership with OrganiCup (now AllMatters) and Benny & Freddy. 204 cups were received; 150 were distributed to primary programme beneficiaries across six Nigerian states, and the remaining 64 cups were made available to stakeholders and interested parties to trial and assess the product.

Organisation	Girls for Development Goals Foundation (GDGF), Asaba, Delta State
Period	October 2020 – March 2021 (distribution began November 2020)
Corporate Partner	OrganiCup (now AllMatters), Denmark · Benny & Freddy
States	Delta · Kebbi · Adamawa · Abuja (FCT) · Lagos · Enugu
Geographic Scope	All 6 geopolitical zones of Nigeria
Total Cups Received	204 OrganiCup menstrual cups (received September 2020)
Beneficiary Distribution	150 cups — adolescent girls and young women across 6 states
Stakeholder Distribution	64 cups — given to stakeholders and interested parties to trial and assess
Implementing Partners	6 grassroots organisations — one per state
Media Coverage	Nigeria Health Watch — 'Cupping the Flow', March 17, 2021

204 Total Cups Received	150 Distributed to Beneficiaries	64 Shared with Stakeholders	6 States / Geopolitical Zones
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"Any girl that has attended public secondary school, especially boarding school, has a story about menstrual poverty. All of us at GDGF share that experience."

— *Benedicta Uweru-Apuamah, Co-Founder, GDGF. Nigeria Health Watch, March 2021.*

Executive Summary

The Bloody Cup Campaign was implemented between October 2020 and March 2021 by Girls for Development Goals Foundation (GDGF) in partnership with OrganiCup (now AllMatters) and Benny & Freddy. The campaign aimed to address period poverty, improve menstrual health literacy, and pilot community-led menstrual cup adoption across Nigeria using a decentralised grassroots model.

OrganiCup donated 204 menstrual cups, received by GDGF in September 2020. Of these, 150 were distributed to primary programme beneficiaries — adolescent girls and young women across six states covering all six geopolitical zones of Nigeria — through six local implementing partner organisations. The remaining 64 cups were made available to stakeholders and interested parties to trial and assess the product, extending the campaign's awareness and advocacy reach beyond its direct beneficiary cohort.

Key outcomes included high acceptance of menstrual cups when education preceded distribution, improved menstrual health knowledge across all six sites, reduction in menstrual stigma at community level, and strengthened capacity of six grassroots organisations as trained community health educators. The campaign was featured in Nigeria Health Watch in March 2021.

Strategic Context

The Bloody Cup Campaign emerged directly from GDGF's monitoring and evaluation findings across its earlier programmes. Having distributed disposable sanitary pads since 2016, the Foundation identified a critical structural gap: disposable pads address an immediate need but do not solve period poverty. They must be repurchased monthly — a recurring cost that families in underserved communities cannot sustain.

The M&E finding that drove this campaign: *Distributing disposable pads helps girls this month. It does not help them next month. True menstrual health equity requires a solution girls can rely on long-term without depending on NGO distribution cycles. A menstrual cup, with proper care, lasts up to two years.*

About the Partnership

OrganiCup (now AllMatters)

OrganiCup — now AllMatters — is a Danish menstrual cup company founded on the mission of making menstrual health sustainable and accessible globally. OrganiCup donated 204 menstrual cups to GDGF, received in September 2020. Their medical-grade silicone cup can be reused for up to two years, eliminating monthly pad expenditure and reducing menstrual waste.

Benny & Freddy

Benny & Freddy provided financial support enabling the logistics, facilitator costs, and community engagement activities required for multi-state implementation.

First European corporate partnership: OrganiCup's donation of 204 cups to a Nigerian grassroots NGO reflects an international recognition of GDGF's community credibility and mission alignment — the Foundation's first partnership with a European corporate entity.

Geographic Coverage and Implementing Partners

GDGF deployed a decentralised model, partnering with one vetted grassroots organisation per state — enabling contextualised, culturally sensitive, trust-based delivery across all six geopolitical zones of Nigeria.

State	Geopolitical Zone	Implementing Partner	Setting
Delta (Warri)	South-South	Reaching Out Organisation	Community/church
Adamawa	North-East	Today for Tomorrow Organisation	IDP Camp
Kebbi	North-West	Kungiyar Tallafin Matta Organisation	Rural community
Enugu	South-East	Renaissance Girl Care Foundation	Community
Lagos	South-West	The Lassian Foundation	Community
Abuja (FCT)	North-Central	Sisters by Heart Foundation	Urban community

Accountability: All partners operated under signed agreements, submitted monthly reports, and provided means of verification including photos, videos, and activity summaries. Social media and donor engagement were centrally coordinated by GDGF.

Target Population

- Adolescent school girls
- Out-of-school girls
- Young women
- Internally Displaced Persons (IDPs) — Adamawa State

IDP inclusion: The Adamawa State component — delivered through Today for Tomorrow Organisation in an IDP Camp setting — extended sustainable menstrual health support to one of Nigeria's most marginalised communities, where period poverty is compounded by displacement.

Key Activities

Menstrual Health and Hygiene Education Sessions

All participants completed survey forms prior to product distribution. Education sessions covered menstrual health basics, menstrual cup function, correct use, care, and safety. Education always preceded distribution.

Practical Demonstrations on Menstrual Cup Use

Hands-on demonstrations using anatomical models were conducted at all sites, enabling participants to understand cup insertion and removal in a safe, non-judgmental environment — critical to building confidence and reducing anxiety.

Distribution of Menstrual Cups — Primary Beneficiaries

150 of the 204 OrganiCup cups received were distributed to primary programme beneficiaries — adolescent girls and young women — who expressed willingness to try the product following training. Distribution was explicitly voluntary.

Distribution of Menstrual Cups — Stakeholders and Interested Parties

The remaining 64 cups were made available to stakeholders and interested parties to trial and assess the product. This extended the campaign's reach beyond its direct beneficiary cohort — placing cups in the hands of health advocates, community leaders, and individuals with influence over menstrual health conversations, enabling them to form first-hand opinions on the product and advocate for its adoption with credibility.

Blood Cup Squads — Focus Group Discussions

Structured focus group discussions — the 'Blood Cup Squads' — were held at each site, creating spaces for participants to speak openly, ask questions, and challenge myths collectively, generating rich qualitative data.

Community Sensitisation and Myth-Debunking

Sessions addressed menstrual taboos, cultural beliefs around insertable products (including virginity-related concerns), and barriers to cup acceptance. Parent-inclusive sessions were held in communities where parental resistance was identified.

Monitoring, Follow-Up, and Community Engagement

Trained volunteers conducted up to five follow-up visits per participant group — checking in on cup use and comfort, reinforcing safety messages, and enabling continuous learning and adaptive support throughout the campaign period.

Participant Stories

The following experiences, documented by Nigeria Health Watch in March 2021, illustrate the lived impact of the campaign on individual participants.

Ochuko Samson, 16 — Delta State (Warri)

A secondary school student preparing for her senior certificate exams, Ochuko had missed more classes than she could count since her periods began — unable to afford approximately N450 (\$1.10) for pads every month. She received her menstrual cup in November 2020 at a Sunday church service where GDGF volunteers trained her and approximately 39 other girls and women. Since then, she no longer misses school due to her period, no longer worries about pad costs, and no longer fears leakage.

Rahab Musa, 21 — Adamawa State (Damare community, outskirts of Yola)

A student at Adamawa State University, Rahab described period poverty as almost a monthly reality — staying home from lectures on months she could not afford pads, and using cloth strips as an alternative that on one occasion caused a serious infection requiring medical treatment. Since receiving her cup in November 2020, worrying about pad costs has become history.

Avwaruroro Oghenefejiro, 20 — Delta State (Warri)

A student at Delta State University, Avwaruroro described menstruation as always bringing fear of not being able to afford a pad. As a student, some months she had to forgo other needs to buy pads. The donated menstrual cup has completely overcome that challenge.

Source: Abubakar, B. *Nigeria Health Watch*, March 17, 2021.

Participation and Uptake Insights

Survey responses completed prior to distribution indicated the majority of participants had previously relied on disposable sanitary pads. Overall acceptance of menstrual cups among recipients was high — all 150 individuals who received a cup expressed willingness to try or adopt its use following training.

A larger number of females participated in training than ultimately received cups — attributable to: (1) some participants choosing to attend training without receiving a cup due to personal or cultural considerations; and (2) demand exceeding supply at some sites.

Key design principle confirmed: *Separating education from product distribution ensures menstrual health education remains universally inclusive while allowing individuals to adopt new products at their own pace. This principle will be embedded in all future GDGF menstrual health programming.*

Key Learnings and Risk Mitigation

Core principles confirmed:

- Education must precede product distribution
- Local trainers significantly increase trust and uptake
- Follow-up and peer support improve sustained use
- Flexibility is critical across cultural and geographic contexts

Learning 1: Cultural and Parental Perceptions Around Virginity

In some communities, parents expressed concern that cup use could affect virginity — concerns rooted in cultural beliefs rather than medical evidence. Early caregiver engagement, female community trainers, and framing the cup as a health tool proved effective mitigations. Participation remained strictly voluntary where resistance was high.

Implication for future programming: *Future rollouts will include parent-inclusive sensitisation sessions and culturally appropriate messaging prior to distribution.*

Learning 2: Behavioural Comfort With Insertable Products

Some participants were unfamiliar with insertable menstrual products. Anatomical model demonstrations, emphasis on choice between pads and cups, and ongoing peer support effectively built confidence over time.

Implication for future programming: *Cup distribution should always be paired with extended education, optional follow-up, and clear reassurance that adoption is not mandatory.*

Learning 3: Safety, Misuse, and Clinical Considerations

One participant inserted the cup too high, wore it for up to four days, and developed a minor infection requiring a brief clinical intervention for retrieval. No long-term harm was reported and the individual recovered fully. This isolated case reinforced the importance of clear, repeated safety guidance on placement, removal, and maximum wear time.

***Implication for future programming:** Future projects will strengthen safety messaging, re-emphasise wear-time limits, and incorporate referral pathways to local health providers where possible.*

Outcomes and Impact

Improved menstrual health knowledge and confidence

Participants across all six states demonstrated improved knowledge of menstrual health and correct cup use following education sessions.

High acceptance of menstrual cups

All 150 primary recipients expressed willingness to adopt cup use — with uptake highest where education was delivered by trusted local female trainers.

Stakeholder awareness and product assessment

64 cups distributed to stakeholders and interested parties created a secondary wave of menstrual cup awareness — placing the product in the hands of health advocates, community leaders, and influencers who could assess it first-hand and promote adoption with lived experience.

Reduction in menstrual stigma at community level

Blood Cup Squad discussions measurably reduced stigma-laden conversations about menstruation in participating communities, creating more open dialogue about periods across all six sites.

Strengthened grassroots partner capacity

Six local organisations were trained as menstrual health educators — a lasting investment in community-level health education infrastructure.

National media validation

Coverage in Nigeria Health Watch provided independent external validation, featuring participant testimonies from Delta and Adamawa states. Published March 17, 2021.

Proof of concept for rural cup adoption

The campaign proved that sustainable menstrual solutions can thrive beyond urban centres — when delivery is community-led, education-first, and culturally sensitive.

Beneficiaries Summary

Category	Details
Total cups received	204 OrganiCup menstrual cups (September 2020)
Cups — primary beneficiaries	150 adolescent girls and young women across 6 states
Cups — stakeholders	64 cups given to stakeholders and interested parties to trial
States covered	Delta · Kebbi · Adamawa · Abuja (FCT) · Lagos · Enugu

Geopolitical zones	All 6 geopolitical zones of Nigeria
Implementing partners	6 grassroots organisations — one per state
Target population	School girls · out-of-school girls · young women · IDPs
Follow-up visits	Up to 5 per participant group
Corporate partners	OrganiCup (now AllMatters), Denmark · Benny & Freddy
Media coverage	Nigeria Health Watch, March 17, 2021
Cumulative GDGF reach 2016–2021	4,100+ individuals across 5 completed programmes

Media Coverage

The Bloody Cup Campaign was featured in Nigeria Health Watch in an article published March 17, 2021 — 'Cupping the Flow: Reusable Cups Putting an End to Period Poverty in Nigeria' by Bashar Abubakar. The article documented participant testimonies, profiled GDGF's approach, and challenged governments and organisations to address menstrual product access as a core health and education equity issue.

Full article:

<https://articles.nigeriahealthwatch.com/cupping-the-flow-reusable-cups-putting-an-end-to-period-poverty-in-nigeria/>

Partners and Acknowledgements

- OrganiCup (now AllMatters), Denmark — for donating 204 cups and enabling GDGF's first sustainable menstrual product distribution programme
- Benny & Freddy — for financial support enabling multi-state implementation
- Today for Tomorrow Organisation, Adamawa — implementing partner (IDP Camp setting)
- Kungiyar Tallafin Matta Organisation, Kebbi — implementing partner
- Reaching Out Organisation, Delta (Warri) — implementing partner
- Renaissance Girl Care Foundation, Enugu — implementing partner
- The Lassian Foundation, Lagos — implementing partner
- Sisters by Heart Foundation, Abuja — implementing partner
- Bashar Abubakar and Nigeria Health Watch — for documenting the campaign's impact
- The 150 girls and young women who received cups — and all participants who attended training regardless of whether they chose to receive a product
- The 64 stakeholders and interested parties who trialled the cup and helped extend awareness beyond the programme's primary beneficiary cohort

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